Emperor Ashoka and the Mauryan Empire

Introduction to the Mauryan Empire

The Mauryan Empire was the first great empire to unite most of the Indian subcontinent under a single ruler. It existed from about 321 BCE to 185 BCE, with its capital at Pataliputra, which is the present-day Patna in Bihar. At its height, under Emperor Ashoka, it stretched from Afghanistan and Balochistan in the west to Bengal and Assam in the east, and from the Himalayan foothills in the north to Karnataka in the south. The empire had an efficient administration, a large army, a developed economy and a rich culture. The main sources of information about the Mauryas are Kautilya's Arthashastra, the Greek ambassador Megasthenes's account called Indica, Buddhist and Jain texts and, above all, the inscriptions of Ashoka.

Who Founded the Mauryan Empire?

The Mauryan Empire was founded by Chandragupta Maurya around 321 BCE. With the guidance and help of his teacher and minister Chanakya, who is also known as Kautilya or Vishnugupta, he overthrew the unpopular Nanda dynasty, ruled by Dhana Nanda, and took control of Magadha. He then expanded his empire to the north-west and defeated Seleucus Nicator, a general of Alexander the Great, around 305 BCE; in a treaty Seleucus gave up territories in the north-west and sent Megasthenes as ambassador, and Chandragupta gave him 500 elephants. Chanakya is believed to have written the Arthashastra, a classic book on statecraft, economics and military strategy. According to Jain tradition, Chandragupta gave up the throne late in life, became a Jain monk and went south to Shravanabelagola in Karnataka. His son Bindusara (about 297 to 273 BCE) extended the empire further south, and Bindusara's son was Ashoka.

Ashoka the Great

Ashoka, also called Ashoka Maurya, ruled from about 268 BCE to 232 BCE and was the third emperor of the dynasty. In his inscriptions, he calls himself Devanampiya Piyadasi, which means "beloved of the gods, of amiable looks". Before becoming emperor, he served as governor of Ujjain and Taxila. After his accession he was a strong and ambitious ruler, and in about 261 BCE, in the eighth year of his reign, he conquered Kalinga, which is the coast of present-day Odisha.

What Changed Ashoka After the Kalinga War?

The Kalinga war was extremely bloody. According to Ashoka's own Rock Edict XIII, about 100,000 people were killed, 150,000 were deported, and many more died of famine and disease. The sight of the devastation filled Ashoka with deep remorse and sorrow. He gave up the policy of conquest by war, called bherighosha, and adopted the policy of conquest by dhamma (dharma), called dhammaghosha, based on non-violence, tolerance, compassion and moral conduct. He embraced Buddhism, under the influence of the monk Upagupta (or Nigrodha, according to some texts). He stopped royal hunting and reduced the killing of animals, tried to make his people happy, and appointed officers called Dhamma Mahamattas to spread the message of ethical living and to look after the welfare of people. He promoted respect for parents, elders and teachers, kindness to servants and animals, and tolerance of all religious sects.

Welfare Measures and Spreading Buddhism

Ashoka built roads and planted shady banyan and mango trees along them, dug wells, built rest houses (sarais) at regular intervals, and established hospitals for humans and animals. He sponsored the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra, held around 250 BCE, and sent missionaries to Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia, Central Asia and the Hellenistic kingdoms. His son Mahinda and daughter Sanghamitra took Buddhism to Sri Lanka. He built thousands of stupas, including the great stupa at Sanchi, and monasteries.

Ashoka's Edicts and Pillars

Ashoka had his messages inscribed on rocks and polished sandstone pillars across his empire, in the Prakrit language and the Brahmi script mainly, and in Greek and Aramaic in the north-west, with Kharosthi used in the north-west too. These are the earliest deciphered royal inscriptions of India; James Prinsep deciphered the Brahmi script in 1837. The famous pillars, such as those at Sarnath, Lauriya-Nandangarh and Sanchi, were topped by sculpted animals. The Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath, with four lions standing back to back on a circular abacus, was adopted as the National Emblem of India on 26 January 1950, with the motto "Satyameva Jayate". The Ashokan edicts mention the southern kingdoms of the Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras and Satiyaputras, showing that these Tamil kingdoms were independent neighbours of the empire.

What Is the Ashoka Chakra?

The Ashoka Chakra is a wheel with 24 spokes, also called the Dharma Chakra or wheel of law, that is carved on the abacus of the Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath. It represents dharma, righteousness and the eternal wheel of law, and symbolises motion, progress and justice. The wheel appears in navy blue at the centre of the white band of the Indian national flag, replacing the spinning wheel (charkha) of earlier flag designs, which was adopted by the Constituent Assembly on 22 July 1947. The 24 spokes are sometimes taken to represent the 24 hours of the day, showing that life and progress are continuous. The same wheel also appears on the Indian national emblem and on the Indian currency.

Decline of the Mauryan Empire

After Ashoka's death in about 232 BCE, the empire weakened because of weak successors, financial strain, a large army and bureaucracy, and the revolt of provinces. The last Mauryan ruler, Brihadratha, was assassinated around 185 BCE by his commander-in-chief Pushyamitra Shunga, who established the Shunga dynasty.

Legacy

Ashoka is remembered as one of the greatest rulers in history. The ideas of non-violence, religious tolerance and welfare of subjects are important in India's modern values. The Indian Navy and Indian Army use the Ashoka Chakra in medals such as the Ashoka Chakra award, the highest peacetime gallantry award.

Quick Facts

- Chandragupta Maurya founded the Mauryan Empire around 321 BCE with the help of Chanakya.
- After the Kalinga war (about 261 BCE), Ashoka gave up conquest, embraced Buddhism and followed dhamma.
- The Ashoka Chakra is a 24-spoke wheel symbolising dharma and progress, in the Indian flag.
- The Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath is India's national emblem.
- The capital of the Mauryan Empire was Pataliputra.